# The Product Backlog

The product backlog contains Product Backlog Items (PBIs) which usually take the form of User Stories. Each story provides a high-level description of the features required in the system for them to achieve their user goals. Some PBIs may be epics (very high-level stories that describe larger features or elements of functionality required that are too big to be completed within a sprint and need to be broken down into smaller stories eventually).

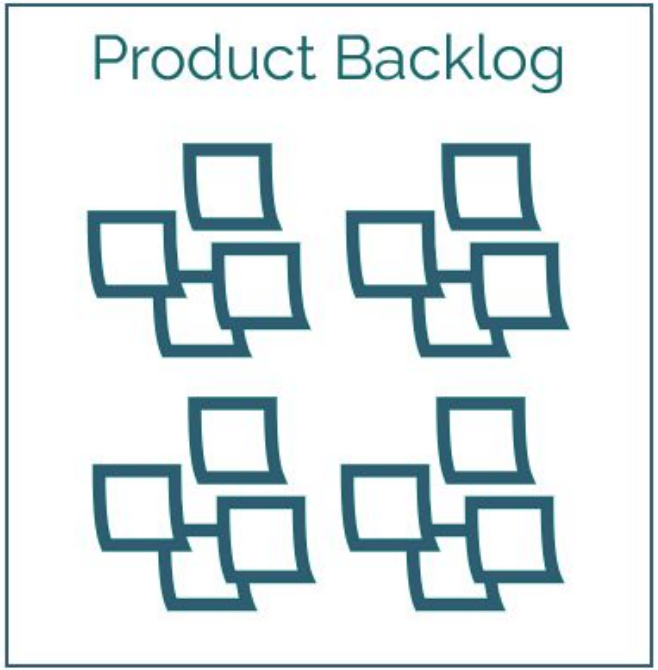
The backlog is in essence a list of requirements for the product. Note however that it does not attempt to document each requirement comprehensively. It is more akin to a list of placeholders for requirements.

# The Product Backlog

New items can be added to the backlog at any time. The backlog, when used with time boxed iterations, supports the concept of delivering working software frequently to deliver value, respond to change and deliver just in time.

User stories that are high level, are commonly known as epics. They are too large to be worked on in a single sprint and will need to be decomposed into smaller stories. The initial backlog can however contain epics, as long as they are sized appropriately and flagged for decomposition before the sprints in which they will be developed.

Backlogs are commonly created and stored in commercially available software tools such as Jira.



# The Product Backlog

When a story is elaborated before a sprint, sometimes it becomes evident that it is larger than originally anticipated. If so, the size estimation is updated. If it is too large to be worked on in one sprint, it is called a spike and treated as an epic. This usually means that other stories will go into the next sprint in the place of the spike, otherwise workflow may be impeded.

Iterations are time boxed periods in which the development team design, build and test features of the system. The time boxes, also known as sprints are relatively short, therefore only a few features can be built during each iteration, often the output is not worth releasing on its own because it will not add value. However, when packaged with the outputs from other sprints, it is likely to be worth deploying (because it will add value). So, the term iteration is used to describe the way in which the solution is developed, and the term increment is used to describe the way in which the solution is deployed.

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There is no rule regarding the number of sprints that will be released in each increment. Except the golden rule that software should only be released if it will add value. So, if for example one sprint focused on building the foundations. Maybe they refactored the architecture so that future integration would be simpler. This alone would not add value to the customer, even though it is fundamental to the build, therefore it may be built, but not deployed until it adds value. There may be a case for deploying if there is internal value. In this example, there may be value to deploying the architectural changes to ensure that existing software will still operate as expected before adding new things.

# The Product Backlog

## Initial backlog

- Validated before the system is designed

## Working backlog

- New stories added
- Epics and spikes decomposed
- Backlog refined
- Stories are made ready and move into sprints

## What next?

- Backlog usually remains in place for future development
- This is because it is product, rather than product focused

# The Product Backlog

**Prioritised List**

Commonly used for agile projects/products
Often created and stored in software such as Jira

**Formed Early**

Formed before the system design and development of the system takes place

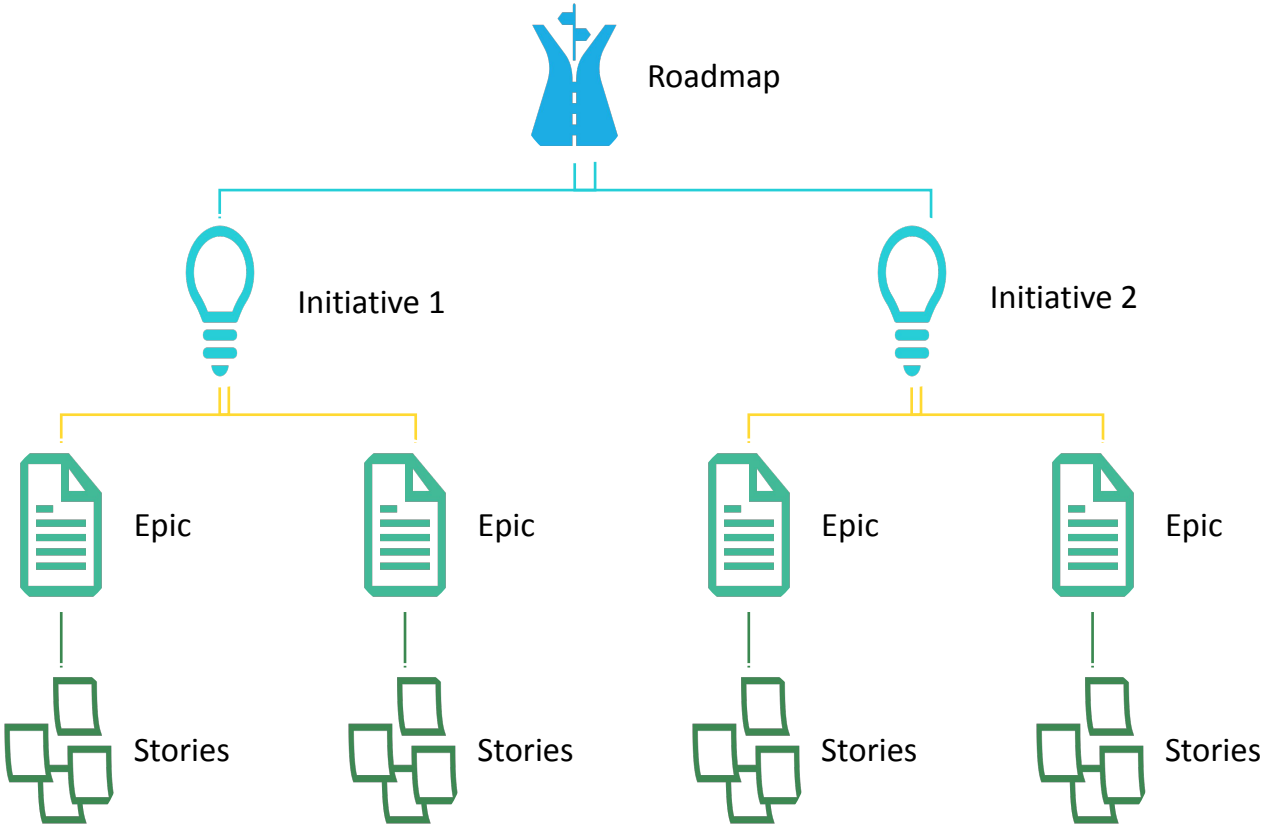
**User Story Format**

The requirements in a backlog are usually written in the user story format
Larger stories are usually referred to as epics

**Evolving**

The backlog evolves throughout, new stories can be added, existing stories are refined.
Change is welcomed if it achieves value

# Hierarchy of User Stories



# Roadmap and Initiatives

## Roadmap

The roadmap is aligned to the strategic plan and includes high level organisational milestones which may evolve into change projects if and when funding is released.

## Initiatives

Initiatives offer another level of organisation above epics. Initiatives are collections of epics that drive toward a common goal.

An initiative may compile epics from multiple teams to achieve a much broader and bigger goal than any of the epics themselves.

# Epics

## Epics

Epics are large stories that are really collections of other stories. Epics can help the Product Owner with project planning and tracking. Epics are akin to high level requirements. They are too large to be estimable and may be worked on by more than one team.

For example. As a Swim Club Manager, I should be able to set up a new club member account. Lower level activity is contained within the account set up.

1. Setting up name, address, phone number
2. Setting up payment information
3. Adding a photograph

# Epics

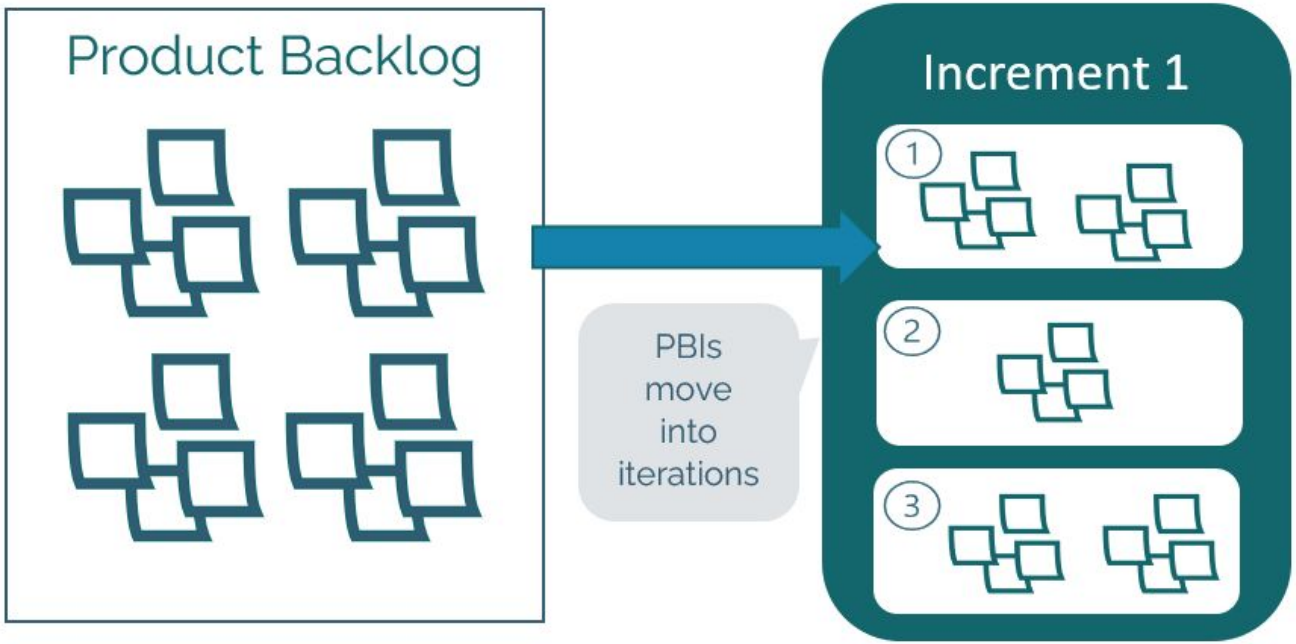
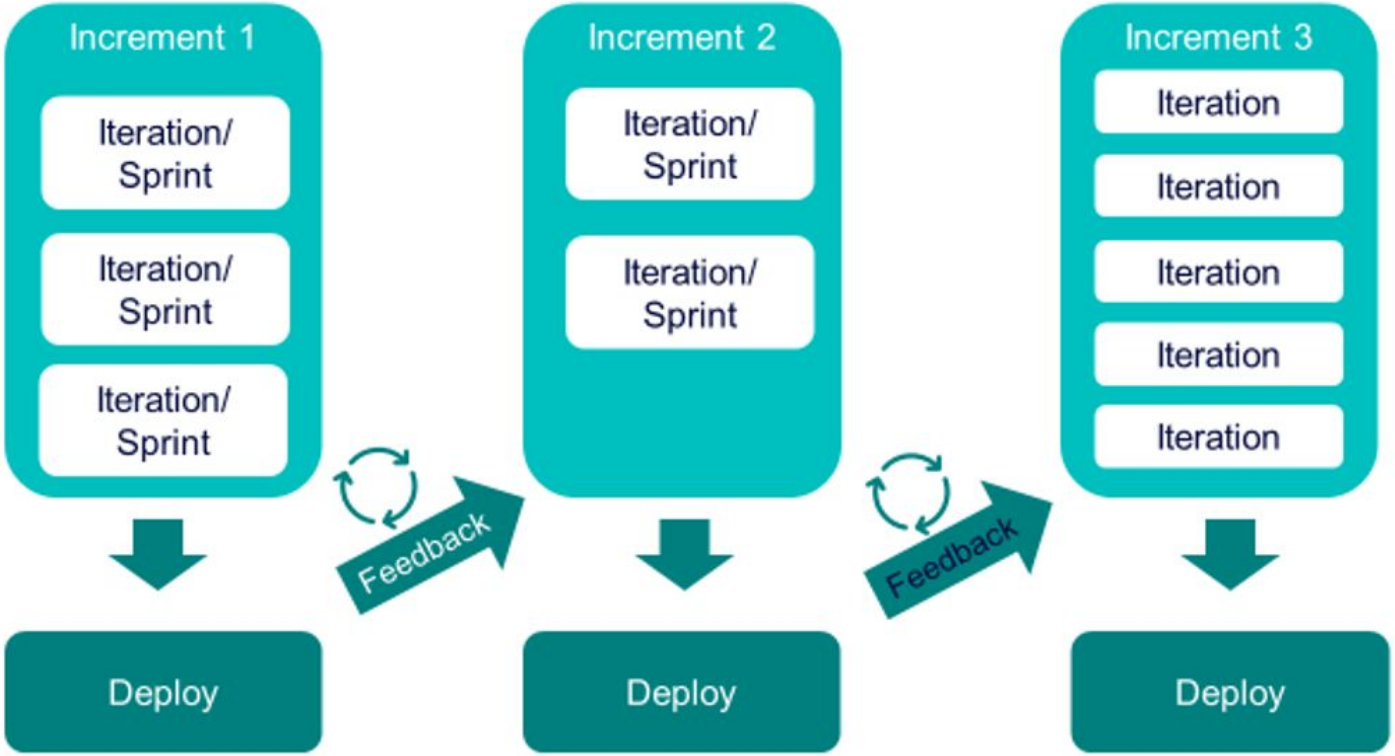
## Epics

When taking a top-down approach, the epics will be elicited first, and further activity will be undertaken to drill down into each epic so that the user stories emerge.

An alternative is to simply work with users and business representatives to elicit stories. When using this approach, some epics will emerge, some stories will emerge. The epics will need to be decomposed before they are worked on by development teams.

# Increment

There may be many time boxed iterations in an increment and many increments deployed for a product or project.



# Incremental & Iterative Delivery